

2.1 vs. 5.1?

A good quality 2.1 is better for music than a similarly priced 5.1. However, the 5.1 is better for games and movies

5.1 vs. 7.1 surround sound?

A 7.1 is overkill if there's not enough room behind the listener and the room is small in size

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With advances in technology, home theatre systems have evolved so that they no longer are the domain of the super-rich. When you go out to buy a home theatre system, the demonstration is conducted in specially built rooms where the sound quality of the system blows you away. However, when you listen to the same set at home, it doesn't sound the same.

As far as the question of buying a home theatre setup goes, it's a very subjective matter. Speakers and sound quality are relative. What's music to our ears may be noise to others. That's why

information about such audio setups from online forums.

Acoustics

Room acoustics is one of the most important and most neglected parts of a home theatre setup. The only design to absolutely avoid from an acoustics standpoint is a square-shared room. Anything else is acceptable. While you can hire professionals to handle how your home theatre room will sound, there is no reason why with a little work, you cannot do it yourself.

Make sure the room is isolated from outside noises. While there's not much one can do after construction, try to make the room as air-tight as possible to prevent sound going either in, or out of the

reflections and redirect the sound energy throughout the room. The ideal seating position should be some distance away from the back wall to avoid reflections. The back wall and ceiling are preferred spots to place diffusers. Something like a bookcase against the back wall is an excellent method to diffuse sound as well as act as a bass trap.

You can use soundproofing material like cork board, glass wool, fibre glass, or even simple foam in a pinch to absorb reflections from the side walls. This doesn't mean you need to line the whole room with the stuff. A completely dead room is useful only for testing speaker response, and may actually be uncomfortable to our ears. Treating roughly 30 per cent of the room is a good rule of

Home sound home

Simple modifications like room configuration and speaker placement can boost your home theatre experience

it's very important to try out any system before actually buying it. Go to the showroom with a DVD of your favourite movie or a CD (or another high quality audio source) of your favourite band and then get whatever sounds best to you. Other than the well-known consumer names, there are many brands audio enthusiasts swear by that actually provide much better quality for similar (and higher) prices. You won't necessarily get the best quality from a Sony or even a Bose for that matter as compared to what you may end up paying for it. You can find detailed

room. Use the basic 'Clap Test' to check the room for echoes. Stand in different parts of the room and try clapping to see the amount of echoes that you get. Our aim is to minimise these echoes in the final setup. Concrete walls are not recommended for such a room. In case there is no other option, consider lining the wall with sound absorption material to avoid bass from booming against your walls.

For shaping a room's acoustics, you first need to take care of primary reflections from the walls. This requires the use of diffusers designed to diffuse sound

thumb to follow in such cases. Stuff like heavy drapes on the windows, rugs and carpets can also be used to cover reflective (literally) surfaces and absorb sound. Unless your speakers are designed to radiate sound in all directions, it's a good idea to place absorption material behind the speakers as well to absorb unneces-

